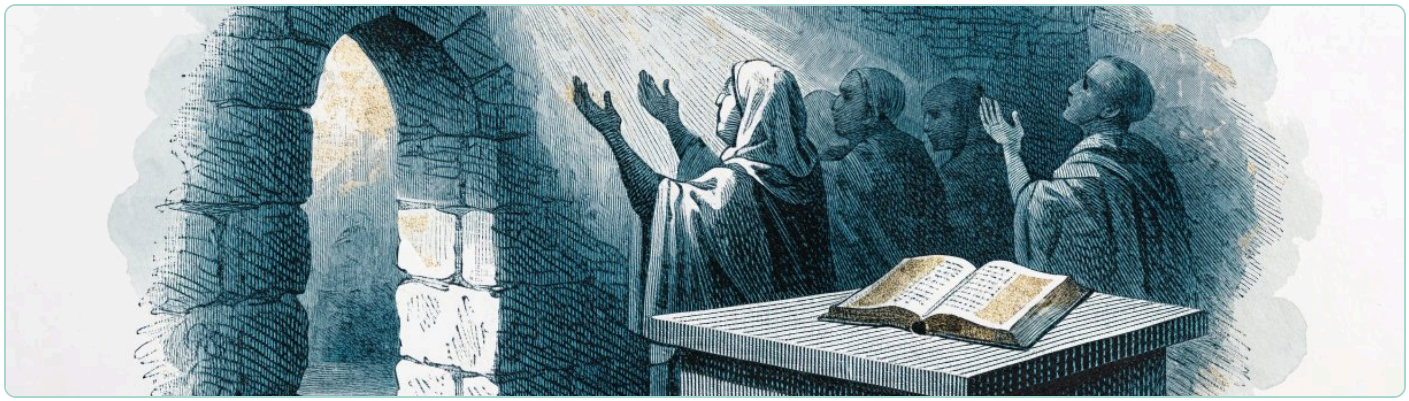


Worship in Spirit and Truth

What makes worship good, and who it is really for



> **John 4:23** *"The true worshipers will worship the Father in spirit and truth, for the Father is seeking such people to worship him."*

If you want to know what a church believes about God, go to one of its funerals. Gene Edward Veith once wrote about two. Both were for young people who died senseless deaths. The first was built around the young man: his favorite song, funny stories, a video of his life. People walked out saying, "What a beautiful funeral." The second was for a girl murdered by a serial killer. The church sang old hymns about the death and resurrection of Jesus, read Scripture together, and heard a sermon about the sure hope we have in Christ. They wept. But Veith said that at the second funeral, "the Word of God that permeated the whole service was like a lifeline."

The difference was not music style. Voddie Baucham put it well: "This was not a matter of preference. This was a matter of fundamental presuppositions." One service tried to manage the room. The other told the truth about God and trusted that it would be enough. This short study asks what worship is, and who it is really for.

Five things to remember

1. **Everyone worships something.** The question is what.
2. **God sets the terms,** and he gives us freedom in style.
3. **We worship the Father, through the Son, by the Spirit.**
4. **Jesus is worthy,** and he makes us able to worship.
5. **Truth comes first, and the heart follows.** All of life is worship.

1. Everyone worships

We tend to think of worship as something religious people do on Sundays. The Bible says every human being is a worshiper. When people turned from God, they did not stop worshiping. They "exchanged the truth about God for a lie and worshiped and served the creature rather than the Creator" (Rom. 1:25).

John Calvin said the human mind "is, so to speak, a perpetual forge of idols." Tim Keller put it this way: "We will either worship the uncreated God, or we will worship some created thing (an idol). There is no possibility of our worshiping nothing." A career, a child, a reputation, a romance: good gifts become idols when we ask them to give us what only God can give. And the forge does not shut down when we walk into church. We can even worship the feeling we get in worship.

> **προσκυνέω** *proskyneō*
>
> The most common New Testament word for worship. It means **to bow down**, to show by your posture that someone is greater than you. When the devil asked Jesus to "fall down and worship me," Jesus answered, "You shall worship the Lord your God and him only shall you serve" (Matt. 4:9–10). Worship begins with bowing. You serve whatever you bow to.

2. Who sets the terms?

Right after the tabernacle was dedicated, two of Aaron's sons, Nadab and Abihu, offered "unauthorized fire before the LORD, which he had not commanded them." Fire came out from the LORD and killed them (Lev. 10:1–2). Notice how Moses describes their sin: fire "which he had not commanded them." They decided for themselves how to come near a holy God. God's answer explains everything:

> **Leviticus 10:3** *"Among those who are near me I will be sanctified, and before all the people I will be glorified."*

R. C. Sproul drew the simple conclusion: "We are to worship God how God wants us to worship Him." The church has often slipped into a different rule. Baucham calls it the affective principle: "If somebody likes it and it makes them feel close to God, it's good." That makes my feelings the test of whether God was honored. But God, not the worshiper, decides what pleases him.

Does that mean the Bible tells us what instruments to use? No. The Westminster Confession, a summary of what Reformed churches believe, helps us here. The **elements** of worship are the things God himself has given: reading and preaching his Word, prayer, singing his praise, and the sacraments of baptism and the Lord's Supper (the two signs Jesus gave his church). The **circumstances** are things like the time, the place, and the order of service. These are "to be ordered by the light of nature, and Christian prudence, according to the general rules of the Word" (WCF 1.6). Most Reformed churches today treat song choice, instruments, and musical style the same way.

What God Commands, and Where He Gives Us Freedom

The elements are fixed by God. The circumstances are ordered by wisdom.

ELEMENTS

Given by God

- Reading the Scriptures
- Preaching the Word
- Prayer
- Singing God's praise
- Baptism and the Lord's Supper
- Giving
- The blessing (benediction)

Given in Scripture (Acts 2:42; WCF 21.3–5)

CIRCUMSTANCES

Ordered by Christian prudence

- Time and place of meeting
- Building, seating, lighting
- Language and order of service
- Which songs we choose
- Instruments and musical style
- Length of the service

Liberty of style (WCF 1.6; 1 Cor. 14:40)

God fixes what we bring him. We arrange the room with wisdom and love.

So a hymn with a pipe organ and a modern song with a guitar can both be faithful worship if they carry the truth of God to the people of God. Hold style loosely and substance tightly.

3. In spirit and truth

> **John 4:23–24** *"But the hour is coming, and is now here, when the true worshipers will worship the Father in spirit and truth, for the Father is seeking such people to worship him. God is spirit, and those who worship him must worship in spirit and truth."*



"The Father is seeking such people to worship him" (John 4:23).

A Samaritan woman asked Jesus which mountain was the right place to worship. He answered a deeper question. "Spirit" points to the new life the Holy Spirit gives. "Truth" points to what God has shown us in Jesus, who said, "I am the way, and the truth, and the life" (John 14:6).

Do not miss the surprise: "the Father is seeking." Left to ourselves, "no one seeks for God" (Rom. 3:11). We do not come to church to talk God into showing up. We come because he has already come looking for us.

That makes worship Trinitarian. "Through him we both have access in one Spirit to the Father" (Eph. 2:18). We come *to* the Father, *through* the Son, *by* the Spirit. Baucham warned that a visitor could attend many churches for a month and never learn that we believe in the Trinity. When you pray and sing, notice which person of the Trinity you are speaking to and about.

4. Worthy, and made worthy

> **Revelation 1:5–6** *"To him who loves us and has freed us from our sins by his blood and made us a kingdom, priests to his God and Father, to him be glory and dominion forever and ever. Amen."*

Just before these words, John tells us who Jesus is: "the faithful witness, the firstborn of the dead, and the ruler of kings on earth." Start there. Even if Jesus had done nothing for us, he would be worthy of all our praise. Then John bursts out, "To him who loves us." The size of a love depends on who is doing the loving. The one who loves you is God the Son, the risen King. Baucham warns that man-centered worship ends up celebrating "the fact that Jesus was smart enough to figure out how lovable we are." That is backwards.

And his love paid: he "freed us from our sins by his blood." Then he "made us a kingdom, priests." In the Old Testament only priests could come near to God, and even they came carefully. Now everyone who trusts Christ may draw near:

> **1 Peter 2:5** *"You yourselves like living stones are being built up as a spiritual house, to be a holy priesthood, to offer spiritual sacrifices acceptable to God through Jesus Christ."*

Notice the last three words. Our worship pleases God "through Jesus Christ," never because we sang well or felt close to him. He makes us acceptable, though we never deserve it. That humbles us, and it frees us. The struggling believer who can barely get a song out on a hard Sunday offers worship just as acceptable as the most gifted singer in the room, if both come through Christ.

"What about visitors who don't believe yet?"

Worship is offered by God's people to God, so it is never a show designed for an audience. But Paul expects unbelievers to be present, and he hopes that a visitor will be "convicted by all" and, "falling on his face, he will worship God and declare that God is really among you" (1 Cor. 14:24–25). We worship God in words outsiders can understand, and pray that they will meet him there, as many in the Samaritan woman's town did (John 4:39).

5. Heart and head

Is the answer to emotional worship to stop feeling things? No. Jonathan Edwards wrote, “True religion, in great part, consists in holy affections.” But he added, “Holy affections are not heat without light.” True feeling comes from seeing something true about God. The light comes first, and the heat follows. He even said strong feelings are “no sign one way or the other.” A quiet Sunday does not mean God was absent. And real worship has room for tears. Isaiah saw the Lord and cried, “Woe is me! For I am lost” (Isa. 6:5), and God answered with forgiveness.

6. All of life

> **Romans 12:1** *“I appeal to you therefore, brothers, by the mercies of God, to present your bodies as a living sacrifice, holy and acceptable to God, which is your spiritual worship.”*

Your work, your marriage, and your ordinary hours can all be offered to God through Christ. Sunday gathers up the worship of the week and sends you back out to live it.

Five ways to worship this week

1. **Ask the right question.** Trade “Did I like it?” for “Was God honored, and did I hear his Word?”
2. **Prepare your heart.** Read the passage that will be preached, and confess your sins the night before.
3. **Start with who Jesus is.** Before you sing “he loves me,” remember who “he” is.
4. **Mean the words.** If a line is true, mean it. Let your feelings follow what you understand.
5. **Make Monday an altar.** Offer your work to God as “a living sacrifice” (Rom. 12:1).

For discussion

1. Before this study, how would you have defined worship?
2. What idols are you most tempted to bring with you into church?
3. How does it change things to think of God as the one who seeks?
4. What would it look like to treat your work this week as worship?

Do you know the God you worship? You can sing in church for years and never bow to him. The Father is still seeking worshipers. He sent his Son to the cross to make them, and he sends his Spirit to bring them home. If you have never come to him, come now, just as you are, through Jesus. “Whoever comes to me I will never cast out” (John 6:37). His blood is enough to make you a priest, and his worship is the one thing you were made for.

Ready to go deeper? Read the full study, free.

490.life/teachings/worship-in-spirit-and-truth/

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